

communities, being either localized or distributed with meetings for that community topic occurring worldwide at the same time.

3.2 Searching and Browsing Capabilities

Social networking sites must provide some mechanism for users to search and browse for information, ranging from matching other individual users or communities who have shared interests to looking for a new job in a particular industry or location. While most sites are targeted towards either professional or social pursuits, there are a few like Tribe and Tickle that allow comprehensive searching and browsing in both areas.

Social sites devoted to user relationships and dating tend to focus their searching functionality on personal information such as age, gender, current relationships. For equality reasons, most professional networking sites ignore age and gender (except Ryze) and instead focus on searching through users' current jobs and employers. Both social and professional sites allow searching of interests, locations and communities since these are common matching requirements.

Communities, consisting of discussion forums and real world event details, can be searched in terms of keywords in their name or description (e.g. Tribe, Meetup and Ecademy). However, when a keyword is not apparently obvious for a search, browsing the categories of communities is often unwieldy due to the creation of top level categories and no subcategories on many sites, leading to hundreds of communities (tens of pages) being listed within a single category that must be browsed through manually.

Some sites offer unique searching and browsing functionality not found on other sites. For example, LinkedIn, with their partner DirectEmployers, are aiding users in their search for new employment. Ecademy also allows searching of content posted by users in their weblogs. Friendzy allows users to browse classified ads, grouped by type or location. Other sites like Meetup do not focus on searching for users or content at all, but rather on brows-